"Subjectivity is truth; subjectivity is the inwardness of truth– Søren Kierkegaard

PREFACE : INTRODUCTIONS TO TRUTH

Public policy management can be distilled into the question of "how best should public policy be organised to ensure it meets intended outcomes." Though contested, the accepted definition of evidence-based policy making purports that policy should be driven chiefly by iron-clad research-based evidence as opposed to intuitive, ideological, or cultural norms. (P. Cairney, 2016). The approach is hotly contested as implicit is the assumption of linearity of the policy setting process and an ignorance of cultural dimensionality. As Dreze underscores, though rationally, adding eggs to mid-day meals improves nutrition, policy-makers would have to navigate interests of stakeholder groups (poultry businesses), caste politics and cultural factors like vegetarianism (Dreze, 2018) – a dilemma academics christen the policy sausage.

Though under fire from post-modernist perspectives, EBP's continued popularity is reflective of the 'modernist' faith in reason-driven progress and its role in reflexive social learning (Sanderson, 2002). In keeping with this, Peter Singer's effective altruism places rationality above all else. In his own words, it is "a commitment not to a particular solution, but to following the evidence." For eg, following a tailored ritual of rationality the movement arrives at the conclusion that advancements in alternate proteins are the panacean cure to livestock emissions. However, this is far from reflected in policy setting. Pushback from farming communities led to the banning of alternate meat in Florida (Samantha, 2024). Was this outcome inevitable? or was there more the movement could have done to coalesce result-based outcomes with policy-maker agendas. On the flip-side, the relentless pursuit of logic led it to found whole think tanks dedicated to identifying underserved cause areas through RCT's. The research led to establishment of LEEP, the lead paint elimination project. Exposure to lead paint in children can cause anaemia, stunted growth, mental illness etc. Lobbying efforts now means ministries in Ghana, Senegal, Angola, Madagascar and 18 others are now taking steps towards lead paint regulation where there was previously none. (Richie, 2022)

Lastly, there is something to be said however, about the pursuit of evidence itself, whether it adopts a results-first agenda, a government's commitment to evidence about the efficacy of its programmes, is an internalisation of its primary objective to design policy that best serves the people. In in that sense, a pursuit of evidence serves the basic agenda of public policy laid out at the beginning of the abstract. As Glennerster, who's work we'll draw upon extensively puts it, "(collaborations are effective when institutions have), a commitment to learning the truth about whether its programs are effective."

To answer whether there are limits to the extent policy should be evidence-driven, we look at current impediments to scaling EPM and whether they can be satisfactorily overcome. In the interest of eluding general overview in favour of a critical deep dive, we limit the scope of our discussion to development and health policy. The primary aim of this essay is to examine theoretical critiques like the policy sausage, black box and trivial significance and contrast and overlay them with grassroots instances where the academic and policymaking disciplines have evolved to combat said critiques. Simultaneously, throughout we will comment on role of evidence in predominantly bureaucratic South-Asian organisations and the federal democratic republic structure of the United States. Is what works all that matters, do we really know what works? If we know, is it relevant? To this end, the remainder of this essay then focuses

on contextualising evidence, buttressing evidence with motivation from qualitative and community data, integrating evidence into the policy making process and the efficacy of RCT's as a mechanism to isolate theories of change.

THE RISE OF EVIDENCE

"The truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth" – Sworn Testimony

As Jon Baron points out, over most of modern history, humanity did not need evidence-based policy treatment. Effects of urban sanitation, refrigeration, schooling of children were so large that they could be detected using methods that were not rigorous. However, the need becomes acute when we're trying to disentangle smaller treatment effects like 20 percent reduction in the school dropout rate (for an education intervention). (Baron, 2018).

Following a systemic review and meta-analysis, the gold standard in discerning causal treatment effects are randomised controlled trials (RCT's). they control for confounding factors that cause endogeneity they are theoretically poised to isolate causal effects.

The 1940s and 50s saw first RCT's published in medicine. The Salk's vaccine and streptomycin trials marked early success, before which, as Doll(1998) puts it "Standard treatments, tended to be passed from one textbook to another without ever being adequately evaluated."(Doll 1998, 1217). The influence of RCT's in US welfare policy grew in the early 1980s culminating in recent "tiered evidence" social programs where RCT's are the basis on which funding is rewarded. (Baron, 2018).

WHOSE TRUTH? LIMITS TO CAUSALITY

'There are as many truths as there are people" – Neon Genesis Evangelion

A primary barrier to the widespread adoption of the pure evidence-based approach is contextualisation of evidence. Causal empiricism doesn't account for political economy considerations and may oversimplify pathways to adoption. This isn't a nail on the coffin of EBP, but calls for a more realist approach to evidence-generation that looks beyond 'what works', embraces cultural complexity and tackle incentives and agency problems. Institutional attributes cannot be controlled for in RCT's. Integrating qualitative nuances, PEA (political economy analysis) into evaluations and using community based contextual evidence to motivate empirical research may be one solution as our example on India will elucidate.

While 'real world' evidence that lies beyond the comfortable quantitative techniques, may make many an econometrician squirm in their seats, moving policy-making closer to the point of impact and involving community actors in decision making and weaving their stories and qualitative evidence into the realm of evidence, may be the linchpin in bridging the divide between comprehensive and bounded rationality. (P.Cairney, 2002). Economics, while motivated by rational is ultimately a study of people and sometimes numbers don't do the talking. But the role the stories of people have to play, don't render evidence moot, but are sources of evidence in themselves. Banerjee and Duflo's 'Poor Economics 'begins by motivating each RCT with anecdotal evidence from time spent in local communities.

Causality may point to what works, but that might be redundant to policy setting without local context. This dovetails into another crucial misgiving, in the absence of cultural context, studies may not be generalisable and RCT's may lack external validity. What worked in Sierra Leone may not work in India so blind replication of results across geographies is redundant. This issue in turn impedes pathways to scale implementation of EBP. However, proponents of evidence are evolving to respond to these shortcomings.

They also point out that while RCT's replicated globally still may not be generalisable, trying to pinpoint specific policy solutions isn't the only role of RCT's, they are increasingly being designed to isolate behavioural patterns and to recognise **theories of change** that advance knowledge of elusive mechanisms and transcend contexts. (Chupein & Glennerster, 2018)

An example from behavioural economics is hyperbolic discounting. Today I don't care if I get my money in 100 or 101 days but tomorrow, I will care if I get it today or tomorrow. This inconsistency is typically hard to test but a Philippines study found people choosing to restrict access to their own money in the future with rates held constant, anticipating they might be tempted to spend and wanting to skirt that temptation. Economists followed this by designing studies that found providing financial nudges encourages investment in preventive health (Dupas and Miguel 2017; Kremer and Glennerster 2011). We'll elucidate how this theory of change informed policy framing going forward.

To combat external validity, one approach is to replicate studies across geographies. RCT's that tested the efficacy of microcredit replicated across 6 countries influenced mainstream policy opinions (Banerjee, Karlan, and Zinman 2015). Glennerster acknowledges that simply lifting even a globally replicated study and overlaying it without local context is dangerous and suggests a bottoms-up approach that starts by "diagnosing local problem using high quality local qualitative and quantitative descriptive data. Then use the local and global evidence as complementary inputs to assess how well the theory of change that motivated the original research, and which generated positive impact, is likely to hold in the new context." (Bates and Glennerster 2017). An example of how knowledge was transferred across contexts to strengthen evidence is offered by child immunisation incentive research. Though the government in rural Rajasthan offered free immunisation, only 2% of children were immunised. Researchers tried to figure out whether incentives would improve involvement in the scheme. To determine whether it was a demand or supply issue, researchers addressed absenteeism complaint to ensure consistent supply, in one set of randomised villages and in another set offered small incentives like lentils after each immunisation and metal plates at the end of the scheme. After a year, immunization rates in treatment villages with incentives were 6 times more than the control group. The behavioural takeaway was that low vaccination uptake was more a result of procrastination, that small nudges helped overcome, than parental aversion to vaccines. It was also cheaper cause the fixed costs were distributed across more children. Evidence when applied this way, can be powerful, clear driver of policy. Furthermore, when researchers replicated the results from Rajasthan across Sierra Leone and Pakistan, though cultural contexts were varied the behavioural pattern of a drop of after the first vaccine was consistent, as was the theory of change around overcoming procrastination with momentum from financial incentives.

KNOWING VS DOING: PATHWAYS TO ACTIONING EVIDENCE

“"Knowing is not enough; we must apply. Willing is not enough; we must do."- Johann Wolfgang von Goethe

A second concern that would limit the extent to which evidence is useful in policy is the chasm between academic pursuit of evidence and it’s relevance to policymakers. Evidence needs to ensure that it a. accounts for the policy-making process and complex development pathways and b. answers questions pertinent to policymakers.

A primary approach is to design RCT’s and research questions that directly address tumultuous political debates. An example is using evidence based RCT approaches to answer questions like William Easterly’s and Dambisa Moyo’s critique of foreign aid and their suggestion to charge consumers in low-income countries for deworming treatment or malaria nets. It was stipulated that people who paid for resources would be more likely to use them and that it would help allocate scarce resources. It was also supposed to make programmes more efficient by generating revenue. The counter was that charging fees would exclude the poorest from accessing services. There was no conclusive end to the debate until researchers conducted a series of RCT’s over 15 years. The results present lucid, policy-relevant evidence that subsidising fees and reducing cost sharing were most effective. (Kremer and Glennerster 2011; Dupas and Miguel 2017). Reducing user fees for necessary preventive health items has garnered support from Save the Children UK, the United Nations Millennium Project etc. The World Health Organisation (WHO) recommended the free distribution of bednets sprayed with insecticide to governments in 2007. The free distribution of bednets increased significantly between 2000 and 2015, averting an estimated 450 million cases of malaria and contributing to a 40% decrease in the incidence of the disease across Africa. Malaria mortality in sub-Saharan Africa fell from 764,000 to 395,000 throughout this period, a nearly half drop. According to biomedical modelling, up to 68% of these cases may have been avoided with greater coverage of insecticide-treated bednets. Bhatt et al. (2015); WHO, 2015). A good example of evidence-based evaluation of policy.

To address the institutional divide more directly, researchers recognise that governments have the advantage in triggering scale reform and involve them in research design to ensure alignment of objectives as the study progresses. In 2012, when Indonesian government’s 2 billion rice subsidy programme was only delivering 1/3rd of the intended amount of rice to eligible houses, they formed a partnership with researchers to find whether identification cards could improve targeting and plug supply leaks. RCT’s found that the ID cards that specified the amount of rice households were entitled to increased subsidy uptake by 26%. The theory of change identified meant the identification system was expanded to cover 2 more direct cash transfer schemes. (Banerjee et al. 2016).

Operational roadblocks however remain to smooth collaboration. The policy-setting cycle often predates the research cycle (Pawson, 2002) which has seen ‘realist synthesis’ emerge - where policymakers look to previous systemic reviews. In the Indonesian case, policymakers needed an answer in enough time for the annual budget. Here, the researchers were able to respond rapidly in part due to specialisation in the domain and a standing relationship with the government in power built over time that allowed them to furnish case-specific, contextualised evidence. In the long run, researchers must proactively mobilise to demonstrate receptiveness to the implementer's priorities, flexibility in evaluation methodology, responsiveness to inquiries, and sustained involvement with local stakeholders throughout the evaluation process. On the flexibility and the power to disseminate responses at scale make a policy-institution a good partner.

Factors identified to create environments conducive to research-policy collaboration include:

i. Strong demand-driven approach to the partnership with favourable baseline institutional culture with an internal champion.
ii. Delineation of responsibility between entities in the partnership and a focus on building long-term relationships with a commitment by researchers to iterate on and update research as political economy evolves over time.
iii. A winning strategy amongst research teams has been to extend product offerings. Beyond research assistance, they've evolved to offer technical advice on assessing evidence quality and developing robust monitoring systems. This approach gives the policymakers early wins even before research bears fruit. (Chupein & Glennerster, 2018).

The trivial significance critique of evidence purports that even when RCT's tick all boxes, they may not by consequential enough to make a dent and move people from poverty to prosperity and what really matter are macroeconomic variables like trade policy that can't be subjected to random assignment (Ravallion, 2001). A counterargument for the prior could be the Minnesota Family Investment Programme that decreased the percentage of long-term welfare recipients who were single parents and had total incomes below the poverty line from 85% to 75% while also producing significant increases in employment and earnings of 20 to 40% (Gennetian, Miller, and Smith 2005). A final critique is that a skill-deficit in the public sector may hinder officials from accurately interpreting and applying research-based evidence. (Newman, Cherney, & Head, 2016)

To end this section, we note that the policy questions that evidence was used to answer were generally concise and targeted. Using evidence as the sole factor in determining the approach to broad-spectrum wicked policy problem may pose interesting challenges. But that is beyond the scope of this essay.

EVIDENCE IN POLITICO-ADMINISTRATIVE CONTEXTS

It's widely acknowledged that the use of evidence in policy-making in general and of RCTs stemmed from the United States. Institutions incubated in MIT like J-PAL were instrumental in passing the use of RCT's into the lexicon of international development discipline. Emergence in social arena was staggered but initial studies include Manhattan bail project in 1960's to evaluate releasing defendants without trial (Botein 1965), the income maintenance experiment – a large scale RCT testing the negative income tax hypothesis (Munnell 1986) found evidence to be lacking and discouraged implementation(something the Nixon government was considering) and the Abecedarian study that provided preschool education to disadvantaged children found strong positive outcomes and encourages local bodies to expand early education offerings.(Koshyk et al 2021).

In the mid-1980s, HHS began funding large-scale RCTs of welfare-to-work and other income supplementation programs. Following suit, the Whitehouse also advocated waiving of funding requirements if RCT's were employed. (HHS 1994). In 2002, the Congress passed the Education Sciences Reform Act of 2002 that directed the IES to employ RCT's to commission impact evaluations.

While a brief spurt saw the Trump administration ban the CDC from using terms like 'evidence-based', the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act was passed in January 2019 and required each government agency to name a chief data officer, and an evaluation officer,

This account serves to highlight that the inculcation of evidence into the policy process in a federal republic like the USA is enshrined in it's institutions, whereas in developing countries efforts seem to be led by external agents and involve far-reaching reliance on partnerships. The relevance of weaving cultural contexts and exerting effort to make evidence align with bureaucratic frameworks are accentuated.

However, this case study from India moves us away from the porcelain of the WhiteHouse and offers a masterclass on integrating qualitative evidence in a setting where electricity isn't commonplace. In 2012, the Indian state of Maharashtra conducted a pilot to research using empowered participatory governance for decentralised health planning. The overarching aim was to access community-generated evidence like the quality of provider-patient interface, illegal charges etc. Primary data was collected from nodal NGO's, public hearings ('Panchayati meetings') etc.

Interestingly, bureaucratic processes were tweaked to accommodate new evidence, through active capacity planning, the project included advocating for issuance of state-level orders for CSOs. 3 external evaluators who used mixed methods approaches to analyse the project found "between 21% and 59% of the RKS(village) funds had been used for issues identified through participatory processes, compared with no such expenditures in the pre-intervention year" and a 173% increase in fund utilisation. In Degaon, Pune, the project uncovered that anaemia was a rising concern in pregnancy and the village fund was employed to buy iron kadhais. (Khanna, 2013)

However, while this instance highlights the possibility of constructive integration, bureaucratic frameworks can hinder the uptake of evidence. Gill & Meier (2000) accuse public administration of regressive methodological approaches that fall-behind industry standards. However Luca (2016) employs qualitative field interviews from Turkey to conclude that the accountability that public bureaucracy generates can counteract the disability generated by a lack of autonomy. It also uncovers stringent schools of thought and resistance to change.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

Economics as a discipline is anthropic in nature. It is this very attribute that allows it to participate in the policy discussion. However, as we've demonstrated, maybe employment of evidence needn't be in denial of its anthropic nature. Lastly, while Arrow's theory of impossibility may conclude that efforts are in vain, the chase of contextualised evidence may provide the elixir to designing efficient policy for targeted, well-defined problems.

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